These two testimonies—one a matter-of-fact court affidavit and another, a literary autobiography—though emanating from VOC himself, do not fully reveal the pressing conditions under which the local merchants contemplated a shipping concern to take on BI. We need to explore further.

For quite some time, all had not been well in the wharves of Tuticorin.

No doubt, the febrile political climate of the Swadeshi movement was the backdrop against which the idea germinated. But it was local conditions that provided the kindling for it to catch fire. The high-handed methods of Andrew and Frank Harvey/A. & F. Harvey Bros caused much resentment among native merchants in Tuticorin. Local merchants felt 'serious difficulties in transacting their business with the British India Steam Navigation Company'.[15] Hardships apart, they had to endure insults laced with racism in their day-to-day interactions. Of course, the Harvey Bros were no better or worse than their BI counterparts in other ports. For instance, the Bengal Steam Navigation Company had its origins in an Indian passenger being kicked out from a British liner.[16] The rise of the Swadeshi movement only fuelled British hostility towards Indian enterprise —rather than placate their clients, they turned even more aggressive. Complaints to A. & F. Harvey being of no avail, the merchants wrote detailed missives and telegrams to BI's Calcutta headquarters. But no redressal was forthcoming. The local traders read arrogance rooted in the British monopoly of the Tuticorin–Colombo route in this indifference. With the Swadeshi movement providing the ballast, the traders decided to take matters in their own hands—they resolved to charter steamers on their own.[17] It helped that their needs were simple and well-defined: the import and export of cargo between Tuticorin and Colombo with the possibility of conveying passengers. From the very beginning, the focus was on coastal trade and not deep-sea navigation.[18]

The directors' report of 1907–08 spells out the injustices inflicted on the traders as the rationale for promoting the company. Considering that the entire Tuticorin–Colombo cargo trade was theirs, they wondered why BI should have a monopoly on its shipping and insult them to boot. The